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Michael Moore

Michael Moore is currently one of the most in demand bassists in jazz. He was born in 1945 in Glen Este, Ohio, and started on the acoustic bass at the age of 15. Michael attended the Cincinnati Conservatory and honed his skills with guitarist Cal Collins at the Playboy Club of Cincinnati. After a 1966 tour with Woody Herman he settled in New York and played with an impressive group of jazz artists. Benny Goodman, Marian McPartland, Chet Baker, Herb Ellis, and numerous others have benefited from his virtuosity, and he continues to record and tour with the top jazz musicians in the field. One of his latest recordings is with Arbors artist Rebecca Kilgore, entitled "I Saw Stars."

Michael was interviewed on September 12, 1997 at the Allegheny Jazz Party in Chautauqua, New York by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming this afternoon for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Chautauqua, New York, and I am very pleased to welcome Michael Moore, who Whitney Balliett called "the greatest living bassist." Did you see that quote?

MM: Did I see it — I did one whole room in that article. Well, yeah, I did. Actually it was nice to read but it was tough to live with because I mean I didn't agree, and it's the kind of thing that made a lot of enemies. People I didn't even know would come up to me and say, like I wrote it.

MR: Like you wrote it.

MM: Yeah, you know, that kind of thing. It was a blessing and a curse.

MR: I think it's impossible to say that one person is the greatest living something, because there's so many parameters involved.

MM: Of course. It's not a high jump contest. And I think at the time he had quite carte blanche at the magazine to say whatever he wanted. And I know in later books the editor made him take that first line out, which I agreed with. I think that when he actually went to the editor to publish the book they made him take that out. And so I mean the article was fine without it. It was actually much easier on me and everybody else. But by that time the damage or whatever, had been done.

MR: Right. It will show up for a while in programs, much like it did here.

MM: Right, of course. And I must say I've used it myself in my publicity.

MR: Well your father was a guitarist, and it was a musical family situation?

MM: Yeah, it was. My father was a jazz guitarist and a very good one. And my mother was a vocal music teacher and piano major and taught piano and taught music, actually was my music teacher in elementary school when I was going to school. So yeah, I grew up

playing Charlie Christian solos over and over, and tears running down his eyes, you know, things like that.

MR: No kidding.

MM: And I saw that from the time I was a kid. He was affected very emotionally by the music as I was and so that was a very important beginning.

MR: Did you two end up playing together?

MM: We did, yeah, which also had its flip side to it. My father was also very particular about the bass notes. And he would take me on jobs when I was about fifteen years old, and when I was just finding my way around on the instrument, and I had to go out and fake 30 or 40 tunes in an hour. And as you might expect, I played a lot of wrong notes, and he was not very understanding about it. He somehow thought that I should just know them by a kind of magic. And so that's why I'm still in therapy, Monk, after all these years.

MR: Well gee, faking tunes you don't know on the bass, I mean that's about as hard as you could get.

MM: Well that's a kind of a curse of the instrument though. I mean even though say at a party like this, you'll go up and the horn players will call a tune, and if the piano player knows it, or the guitarist knows it, you're going to play it. They're not going to not play it if you say well gee I'm not sure about this. "Oh, you'll hear it," you know. And that's kind of the nature of the instrument. And I tell my students that. You turn on the radio, or put on a Frank Sinatra record, and play along with it, and try to find the bass notes. Because that's a lot of what the job is about. And you know, very rarely, unless it's your own group, do you get to call the songs. So that's one of the real challenges of being a bass player I think.

MR: Along with carting your instrument around.

MM: Well that's the worst part of it. That's definitely the worst part of it.

MR: Do you ever go to places where they'll provide a bass for you?

MM: Oh I do that quite a bit. I just came off a tour of England and I happened to know the instrument I was going to use in advance, except for one, and that was a bass player whose bass was almost unplayable, so I sounded like that fifteen year old kid again. But you either pay for it by getting the instrument there, so then you're comfortable on the bandstand, or you have it the easiest in getting there and then pay for it on the bandstand. So even if it's somebody else's instrument that's good, it's never set up exactly the way you want it. Oh, it's a real problem. Now Bob Haggart for example is going to use my bass. He didn't want to bring one, so he'll be using mine. So it's not set up, I'm sure, the way he would prefer it to be. But that's what we do with bass players.

MR: You must have got significant classical training in the conservatory?

MM: I did. I didn't stay in the conservatory that long, but when I first started playing the bass I was thumping around on it, and thinking I was getting pretty good. My father brought home a bow, and he said, "Here, try it with this." And it was so depressing when he did it. I didn't touch the bass for about two weeks, and I really thought, do I really want to do this? And he said, "Well if you're going to play the thing, you ought to learn how to play it right." And I started with the principal bassist in the symphony at the time in Cincinnati, when I was still in high school. And then I continued studying with the bow. That first teacher was Harold Roberts, who was the principal, and then I studied with Frank Proto in Cincinnati, who had just come from New York and joined the orchestra there. And then when I moved to Manhattan I studied with Orin O'Brien, who is a lady bassist in the philharmonic. So I continued to study through the years. And then my work with Gene Bertoncini, because he wanted to do a lot of things with the bow, kind of forced me into doing it in public, which was the kind of thing you had to practice at home, and I was afraid to play solos in particular, out. But working with him kind of encouraged me to do that. It made me work on it more.

MR: What is it about his playing that's kept you two together for so many years?

MM: Well I think number one he gets jobs, but I think the thing is that he has a great sense of arranging for the two instruments, again, featuring the bass in a very nice way. And he encouraged me to do things with the bow that I hadn't done, and he came up with — really, most of the time I don't like jazz and classical mixed together. I find that usually it doesn't work for one reason or the other. It takes away from both. But his arrangements seem to work as far as the integrity of both. The classical part was done with integrity, and the jazz was separate enough that that worked. And the timbre of the two instruments, the classical guitar with the bass, it was unusual. I think one of the things that I miss nowadays in music, that there are very few bands around anymore. There are very few arranged groups. And that is for a lot of reasons, economic reasons mostly. And I think that's one of the things that really encouraged me to keep working with Gene is we had material worked out. We have a good repertoire, and we knew — it's nice to go out on the bandstand, for me, and know what you're going to do, and to have the confidence that you're going to get out there and you're going to have material that's going to make it a nice performance for the people, whether you're having a good night as far as improvisation is concerned, or not. You know you're going to be able to go over.

MR: I really enjoy hearing a combo or small ensemble that is basically a jazz unit but every once in a while they'll do something that you know has been arranged and rehearsed. I think it really adds a lot of the performance that that group took the time to do that.

MM: I feel the same way. Like T.S. Monk's band, you know Thelonious Monk Junior, I mean

act together. And the improvisation is very good, but there are a lot of great improvisers around nowadays, but there are very few bands. And my looking back in history, I mean I grew up with the Nat Cole Trio. My father had a trio based like that, on that kind of thing, and those tight arrangements. And Benny Goodman's trios and quartets and all the groups that I admired as I grew up were very well thought out and very well rehearsed, and the improvisation was a great part of it but so were the arrangements. That was why like one of the bands that I worked with in my young years which was so important to me which was George Barnes and Ruby Braff, the quartet record. We rehearsed a lot, and the music shows it, and I still listen to those things and they still sound fresh and good to me because of that.

MR: You went with Woody Herman at a pretty early age.

MM: Twenty years old, yeah.

MR: That must have been quite an experience. You went overseas?

MM: Yeah. I joined the band in Fort Worth, Texas when I was twenty. I remember it was the day after Christmas and I was absolutely petrified. I flew down there by myself with the bass and joined the band and went to work that night. And it was a great band, Sal Nistico and Bill Chase was on that band, Nat Pierce was playing piano, Ronnie Zito was playing drums. And I went through my growing pains with Woody. I was a kid and very insecure, but I ended up staying — it says in the program I was there for three years, but it was just a year I was there. But during that year we did a lot of one nighters and also did a tour. We went to England and then we also went to a two and a half month tour of Africa, a State Department tour, and we were all over Africa. We were playing in Tanzania, Kampala, Uganda. I had my 21st birthday, actually Woody's birthday is the same day as mine, and I had my 21st birthday in Casablanca. And Woody bought me a drink and it was one of my good lines that I came up with. Sometimes you think of them but you think about them too late, but I came up with one. He says, "Son, you've got a life of misery ahead of ya." And I said, "I'm not going to stay on the band that long, Woody." But he loved it, he broke up. But we had, it was Carl Fontana was on that band and there were some great players, and we had a really interesting time in the two and a half months. Very memorable.

MR: Was there a conscious decision at some point, you said I have to move to New York?

MM: Yeah, there was. I was I think 24. I'd come back after working with Woody and I went back and starting working — I had a great job in Cincinnati in the Playboy Club, actually with Cal Collins, who's on this, and I've known Cal since I was a kid. He actually was a friend of my father's. And Cal is one of the great jazz guitar players. I don't know if you're familiar with his playing, but he's always been great, and we had a steady job at

MR: As a duo?

MM: As a trio, with Ron McCurdy, a drummer who lived there. And it was the best job, to this day, that I've ever had. And it was playing jazz five hours a night with a great group and bunnies to look at and great food. And I thought the music business is wonderful. And I didn't know it was going to be steadily downhill from there. And then that came to an end, that job came to an end and I thought well I mean it's back to the same cycle of clubs and stuff in Cincinnati. And I figured well it's time to move to New York. My father never left town, he always stayed in Cincinnati. And I profited I think by his example that, to a degree it was a dead end street for him. He was a much better player and would have had a much better career I think had he moved or taken — he had chances to leave and he didn't. So I thought I didn't want to make that mistake.

MR: When you look at the Local 802 union book, you see an awful lot of players. And what was it like, trying to find a niche?

MM: My wife at the time had a job in New York so it took the financial pressure off, which I think that's the main thing. New York — in that time there was a lot more work in the town, in '68, but it was very frightening to me, so again I was still very insecure and I was not the kind of guy to go out and sit in in clubs and say here I am, which I've known in subsequent years, guys that had that kind of moxie, and I admire that, but I had a few contacts from Woody's band and I think I played with John Bunch someplace, the piano player, and he recommended me to Marian McPartland. And I played with Marian McPartland and she liked me and hired me and that kind of got me started and gave me some credentials and she was very supportive. She played my songs, and was very encouraging. And that was kind of what got me started — working with Marian in New York.

MR: There's some nice quotes in a *Jazz Times* article that just came out, about her. Have you seen it yet?

MM: No I haven't.

MR: I have it with me, we'll take a look at it. It's got you two or three times, talking about her.

MM: Oh really? Oh good, I'd like to see that.

MR: Yes, a marvelous lady. Was this at the Hickory House you played or was that after that?

MM: No it was after that. The Hickory House had closed I think at that point. We worked at a place called The Apartment. The first time I met Ruby Braff was there. He came and sat in with us. And we had a great time traveling around together and playing. It gave me confidence in it. And Bobby Hackett — I actually met Bobby Hackett and played with him at that time. She was doing a Christmas present to a friend, somebody, I forget now, in Europe and she wanted to send a tape. So Hackett came in and read her songs and just,

recorded it, it was at the Fairchild House. And for me it was like — I'd just come to New York and I'm playing with Marian and playing with Bobby Hackett, and it was real exciting.

MR: Years later you played on a record of hers I have — "Ambiance?" There was some pretty adventurous playing on that.

MM: Yeah well Marian and I talked about that recently, and three or four of my tunes were on there, and they were pretty avante garde. I was kind of in that era of player at the time, and Marian, always wanting to be young musically and keep up with what's going on, surrounded herself with young players and wanted to get into what they were into. But it's funny, after that, with me I kind of spent my time in that group of people, like we had a space, it was called The Space, and it was a bunch of musicians and we all shared it and we put on our own concerts in a loft and things like that. And there was a lot of experimental music. Dave Liebman came out of that and Richie Bierach, and a very lot of avante garde things. Right at that time I started playing with Ruby Braff and George Barnes. And I'd grown up playing a lot of traditional music with my father. But you know you're wrapped up with what your peers are doing, and we played a lot of free music and so forth. And I think when I got with Ruby and George and played in that quartet and everything, it kind of re-set me in a way, in a more — not that I stopped playing the other kind of music — but I think in a way it set me, and made me realize how important songs were to me. Songs from the 30s and 40s in particular, with the great songwriters, because that's what they were interested in, was the love of it, the American popular songs. And I think that that really, in a way, brought me back inside more. And I haven't really left that since then. I still really feel that I did my experimentation and I feel now that, as far as like trying that, I feel it was done about as well as it can be done by a lot of players that I loved at that time, in the 60s and around then, and some of the guys are still around, and some of the wonderful Paul Bley, Gary Peacock, and that kind of music.

MR: It's always been a struggle with that kind of music, as far as your audience reception to it I think. I don't know if after a while you say maybe this isn't valid for anyone except myself perhaps.

MM: Well I think it's a lot more fun to do than it is to listen to. I think that's one of the problems with the music, with a lot of that. It can become very self-indulgent. And when I started playing with Ruby and George, everything was thought of as — solos weren't too long — they used Benny's trios and quartets as a good example of where nobody played too long, there were no 40 chorus solos, and musicians were standing around talking to one another. It was thought out with the audience in mind, but also from, I

melody and shape — as much as whether the audience is going to like it or not. And I got wrapped up in that too, and it's to the point now where I can't stand — as a bass player sometimes I find myself in those situations where the horn players are playing chorus after chorus after chorus, and I'm getting bored, so I can imagine how the audience is feeling. Because I've got something to do. And I really think the discipline of that kind of thing is really important in a player, is to — Lester Young could compose in eight bars, something that you can study the rest of your life. He didn't need 30 or 40 choruses to say something. And I think a lot of that got lost in certain periods of exploration. So I don't see that I actually regressed, I see it that I progressed out of that kind of experimentation, and went back to thinking about tighter forms and things.

MR: If you were talking to a group of young musicians, which I know you do a lot, can you describe how you think of your role as a bassist?

MM: Sure. Well I do a lot of teaching and I think that the bass is probably — maybe as Dizzy said that's the first thing he'd get for a big band was a good bass player, and he'd go from there. And I think it is probably that — I wouldn't say the most important — but right in there with the drums and the piano and the rhythm, it's very central. And the feel, the team spirit that you have to develop as a bass player I think is very important. I don't care about the solos, that can come later. But I always tell bass players, time, feeling, is the most important thing that you have to shoot for right away, and work towards that. And solos later on, or at the same time, but never, never forgetting the function of the instrument. And you really have to, in a way, a lot of times a great bass player I think is not noticed. I correlate it to being a catcher. I used to be a catcher in baseball. And I think about it as kind of the catcher. He's not noticed on a ball field, until he makes a mistake. And the bass player is kind of the same way. You shouldn't be noticed that much. You should be felt, and the rhythm should sound good, but the bass shouldn't — until it comes to the solo — he shouldn't stand out as like playing a lot of tricks and things like this. There have been a lot of bass players through the last century that stand out no matter what they do. But I think when you're accompanying you should not disappear, but you should not be so noticeable until it comes time to play solos. And that takes a certain amount of almost Zen attitude of thinking about the unit and putting yourself out in front of the audience and saying how is the band sounding, and thinking about the rhythm section as a unit. And volume has a lot to do with it. You can't be too loud because then you overpower the acoustic instruments on the bandstand. It's very important to set your volume, if you're using an amplifier, to the keyboards, the piano in particular, the acoustic piano. Because it can't get any louder than that is. So if you crank up the amplifier, then the whole thing is destroyed. You haven't got a chance. So there's a lot of

elements that go into it, but mainly being a team player, and kind of maybe subjugating your ego just a little bit, to do it.

MR: The amplification issue, it seems like things tend to get louder as years go by. I'm not sure why.

MM: Well I've noticed it, the whole society is getting louder, everything is getting louder. If you go to the theater, everything is miced very heavily and I don't know whether collectively as the human species our hearing is getting worse all the time, which makes everything get louder, which makes our hearing get worse all the time. I'm sure if we went back 200 years we would be surprised at how quiet everything was. But I think, I go to places where I'm going to play and the sound people will have these huge speakers set up beforehand. And they'll be playing things through the speakers to test them and so forth, and they're having bands on, even jazz records, and they're so loud, I can't hardly stand to be there. And we're constantly talking over the top of music. I mean if you're in a night club, you play, you finish playing, as soon as you finish playing, they turn on the music. But when you come into the place the music is going. So the ear is never hungry for music. You're saturated with sound all the time. And I think there's a certain amount of fatigue that sets in with that too. And I think it's detrimental to concerts. I mean if you go to hear a Mozart string quartet, before you sit down, they're not playing somebody else's recording of the same Mozart quartet through big loud speakers, that was done in a studio with the optimum equipment and so forth and so on. But you go to a jazz club or a concert a lot of times, you come in, and they're already playing the best Benny Goodman Big Band recording, all re-done, through these huge speakers. There's no way number one that you can compete with it in a way, because it's almost an unfair comparison to make. Plus the fact that your ears are worn out by the time the band starts.

MR: That's a great thought. How can you – the anticipation of the music is kind of killed then, because when you come into it it's already there.

MM: It's one of my real pet peeves. I mean you should come in to a room and be anticipating the music and hungry for it, just like you are for a meal. But it's almost unheard of that a club doesn't have the music on, right up to the moment — I mean I can't even sometimes find time to tune up, because the music is going on right to the time the guys get on the bandstand, and there's music playing, and I'm trying to get in tune with the piano, and the music is playing at the same time. And you know — I want silence when I go to a restaurant. I don't care if they're playing classical music, which is better than the rock & roll crap that you have to listen to most of the time, but if I go into a restaurant, I'd just like to hear nothing. I mean I don't want to talk over Beethoven or Mozart. I'd like to sit down and listen to them. I'm like Gerry Ford, I can't eat and listen at the same time.

MR: It's interesting, even tonight it looks like they have a set-up where the people are going to be eating dinner during the first significant portion of this party. These jazz parties are an interesting kind of phenomenon. Do you enjoy making the circuit on these things?

MM: I do. I've been doing them now for I guess I started doing them back in the mid 70s I think. So I've been doing them a long time. I actually enjoy some more than others, depending on the circumstances. The thing that I don't like about them is the fact that they're big jam sessions, and the lack of organization that goes on, because of the nature of the beast. I mean it's a phenomenon that in a way has taken the place of a lot of clubs and things of yesteryear that are no longer in existence. And I'm grateful for them, but again, I think it's sad that everybody's hired as an individual. It's like the George Steinbrenner way of running a baseball team. You hire stars. And that doesn't necessarily mean that they're going to play well together. You know whereas you could take any one of these guys that you've got here and say why don't you bring your group, or a group of guys, and maybe have four or five different groups, as opposed to a name horn player from California, a name horn player from Australia, and everybody meets and says, "What are we going to play?" So I think that's the down side of it. At the same time there's also some magic that happens when you throw those things together too, that may not have happened either. But I think that the thing that I see running through the last twenty years of doing them is this same kind of lack of groups. Now there are a few of the guys that have done it so much that they make you think it was already thought out and well done, almost organized.

MR: Maybe some kind of balance would be nice, if they had a band during part of the evening and then did the more traditional format.

MM: Which I think Joe tries to do here.

MR: Like with Hal Smith's Roadrunners.

MM: He has some groups. And Becky Kilgore and Dave have recorded together so they have material to work from. And then you have somebody like Dave McKenna, which is like a whole orchestra by himself. And so Joe knows how to do it and he knows how to mix guys — like Cal and I doing a duo together, and we have played together over the years. And he knows, to a degree, what's going to work. And it's just again, there's not many groups around anymore, except a few very famous ones.

MR: I wanted to play something for you, and see if you recognize this.

[audio interlude]

MR: Now, this will give it away.

MM: Oh, that's Becky Kilgore. Yeah, I recognized me, in fact, is that on the record?

MR: Yeah. It's called, that's the remake of "The Duke." Tough tune.

MR: I was just looking at it and I said well let me see how he felt about playing on this tune.

MM: That's nice. I don't think I ever heard it.

MR: No kidding? You do so much recording that you probably don't always get to really—

MM: Well I have this record, and I remember, this is the one, "I Saw Stars," right?

MR: Yeah. "Princess." The last tune.

MM: I wonder if I got a cassette of that or something. See, maybe it's not on a cassette. But I didn't think it was on the one I had. Because you know Dan Barrett said you know, "I love your solo" on something, and I said, "Really?"

MR: Well it's there. You think you'll have to go out and buy it?

MM: They got it here. No I do have that, and I love the way Rebecca sounds on there, I just think it's great. Well thank you for playing that. It's always nice to hear myself play something that I like. And it was nicely recorded. A lot of times, a big problem with the bass is the recorded sound. A lot of times it's tough.

MR: They just don't know how you think?

MM: Well I'm probably a little more complicated to record than other bass players, not all other bass players, but modern bass players who use the whole instrument, the upper register. It's hard to get an overall sounding bass. If you stay in one register, stay down in the low register, that's kind of what you're getting when you're accompanying. And it's almost like you're recording two instruments, because it's almost like playing two instruments. So what sounds good soloistically, doesn't necessarily then — you've got to adjust it. It's hard for me in a live situation to get a sound that sounds good for solos and accompaniment too. So it's difficult to record, and the instrument's hard on top of it. Any engineer I think will tell you it's the hardest one to get because it's soft. If you made a string long enough to vibrate that chamber it would be as tall as this room. I mean they made a bass violin where acoustically it was perfect, it takes two people to play it. Because you see the size of the chamber, think of the string on the violin, in proportion to the body, or a cello string in proportion to the body. You think now the same length of string for the body of the bass. It would take somebody on a ladder to play it. So acoustically you're starting off—

MR: A little imperfect.

MM: A very imperfect instrument. And you're always trying to get a big sound out of something that you're not capable of really vibrating the whole thing. So it's tough, it's tough to record. And then in the 70s I did a lot of records and engineers went with the electronic pick-ups, and they got the worst bass sound of all during those periods, because it was easy for them, they didn't have to worry about leakage from drums or anything else, they just plugged it directly into the board. And I can't listen — there's

because of the sound of the instrument. It has a real hard, electric sound, not acoustic at all. And it'll be the only instrument that sounds that way. The piano is okay, the drums are all right and everything else, and the bass sounds like a buzz saw or something.

MR: Did you ever play electric bass?

MM: I did. Actually when I came to New York, everybody said well if you're going to work you'd better play electric bass. I had just bought one and brought it to New York. And a friend of mine, Dave Matthews, was writing for James Brown, he was his arranger. And so I'm actually on some James Brown records.

MR: No kidding?

MM: Yeah. "Talking Loud and Saying Nothing," and a couple of hits he had actually — one about drugs, a waltz about drugs.

MR: And this came in a studio situation, and you knew the fellow who was doing the arrangements?

MM: Yeah. Well actually I went on the road with them, and he'd take two bands. We did the Dick Cavett show with him — he had big band arrangements and I played in that. And then he had his regular band on stage. So we played a couple of places where he carried two rhythm sections. And it was fun. Rhythmically that music is exciting stuff. And so it was fun. But then very shortly after that some guys started showing up who, that was their main instrument in New York. And talking about New York being a place where you find your niche, when Jaco Pastorious showed up playing electric bass, and Will Lee and a couple of other guys who were really into it, I said well I never liked practicing the instrument. It was never for me. I never liked the sound much. And I always thought it was more of a double for a guitar player than for an acoustic bass player. And I never liked it very much, so I said well I was getting pretty busy on upright by that time, and I gave my electric bass away. I could have kept doing it half assed for the rest of my life, but I didn't feel real honest about that, and I felt like the guys that were really serious about it should have the work. I've always been kind of stupid like that, as far as — somebody will call me up for an orchestra date, and I'll say, you know there are guys in New York, that's all they do, they play that stuff great. And so I wouldn't go. And then I'd find out that they hired somebody else that shouldn't have done it either. And I'm sitting at home saying, you know, kicking myself. But there's no justice in any of that.

MR: I'm going to pause just for a second to make sure — did they change your playing schedule at all?

MM: No. I'm still okay. I'm just going to have dinner. While they're playing I'm going to have dinner and try not to make too much noise. Try to concentrate and eat at the same time.

MR: You have received some nice reviews, on this particular CD, I just read one in *Jazz Times*

MM: I didn't know that.

MR: I'll try to find it for you. In fact, I think they mentioned your tune here. "The Old New Waltz." Tell me how that tune came about.

MM: Well I left the country at one point. I actually moved to India in '89. I quit playing the bass, and went to India, and ended up in London. It didn't work out in India, and I ended up in London and was playing piano, but mostly not doing much of anything. And then I started playing bass again over there. But I was spending a lot of time on piano, and I occasionally was coming back to New York. And I spent a lot of time writing around that time, and I didn't think much of that tune. I knew it worked, it was the kind of thing well I thought well it's okay. And then we got called to do this recording when I was going to be back. And everybody was supposed to submit a song. And so I mean I didn't even have it written out properly or anything, so I wrote it out and brought it back. And I have no judgment about the songs that I write. There was a song with Marian McPartland on "Ambiance" called 'Wisdom of the Heart." It was I think the first song that I wrote. And it's just a simple little waltz, very short, kind goes to some interesting place harmonically. And everybody loved that song. I mean people like Gil Evans came up to me and he said, "Have you got any more songs like 'Wisdom of the Heart?'" And I'm saying wow. Alec Wilder liked the song and wrote me a letter about it. And I'm saying, I don't get it. But in daylight it was such a thrill, and Marian liked it, and a lot of people liked that song. It was just a short little waltz. And I wrote this one, and I've had great response from that. People say oh they love the song. People have written lyrics for it that have really loved that song. Another band, I walked into a place in St. Louis, there was a trio there playing this song. It was the first time in my life —

MR: That's a thrill.

MM: They said, "We're going to play your song." And so that had never happened to me before. And so I mean I like it, and I think it's pretty, but I don't have any — and it may be one of the best things I've written. I don't write a lot. I mean I write in spurts. But I knew it worked and it was that kind of thing, but I didn't have any great feeling about it.

MR: That's interesting. The opposite may happen sometime. You may write something that you just think is the best —

MM: Oh that has happened. That's happened more often than the other way around. You kind of say wow. And then you give it to somebody and they say, "That's nice," you know. And so I mean I don't know whether we ever really know or can tell, or whether I can, other people can I'm sure. But you wonder if — Jerome Kern when he finished "All The Things You Are" said I've just written a classic. This is going to be the greatest, one of the great songs ever, and it's perfect. Or whether he just thought well I did that one today,

MR: You wonder if they, how jazz musicians, why they've chosen certain songs to latch on to like that. I mean it seems to be perfect for improvising and the whole thing, but like you said, he may have had no idea that that was going to happen with that particular tune.

MM: Somebody said to me one time, a tune has a life of its own. It's like you're giving birth to a child and you send it out into the world, and you don't know what's going to happen to it or where it's going to go. I really kind of kick myself for not doing more writing, because the more you do it the better — it's like anything else — the more you do it the better at it you get. And to be disciplined enough to sit down every day and say okay I'm going to write for two hours, and whatever comes out comes out. And just kind of let it alone and not re-work it and not go over it and over it again. Just see what happens. Wonderful things happen when you just go to that well every day. And I don't do it enough. I'm a compulsive practicing person. I practice a lot. I don't call it practicing though, I say playing. But I'm not compulsive about anything else. That and pasta.

MR: I hope they have some for you tonight. What, if you don't mind me asking, caused you to want to leave the country?

MM: Oh it was a lot of personal reasons, but financial pressure to a great extent. My wife at the time was of Indian origin. And I was living in Pennsylvania, I was driving 150 miles back and forth every day to work a lot of the time, and barely making ends meet, and things weren't so good financially. And we had the idea of kind of selling our house and moving to India. My son could have gone to private school there with the money we got from selling our house — they were giving 13% tax free interest on it. Over there we could have lived very well. I had this thing I was going to start writing and have my son go to private school. He was young at the time, five or six. And then we'd come back and play, and basically walk away from the rat race. But it didn't work out. Inflation was running at 18%, and so on the fixed income, that was going to be going down. My son would have never caught up in school. They start them at like the age of two over there, or three years old. So there was whole lot of other reasons. So Plan B was to go to England. And it was actually a very good learning experience for me, a growth experience. Because first of all I had gotten to the point where I almost didn't enjoy going to work anymore, didn't enjoy playing music, didn't enjoy the life anymore, and I wanted it to be over. And when I got to England and subsequently that marriage broke up, and all of a sudden I was back in music. I had students and I was playing piano and I went out and I re-discovered that I had this whole life in music, and I re-discovered the love of playing and it was like, people talk about being born again Christians, I was a born again musician. And I started with a whole new attitude. And it was a very good growth experience. It was, you know they say when things are at their absolute worst, wait, and it could be the best thing to

happen. And it turned out the whole process was a very good reaffirmation of music and life.

MR: Well, that's positive. I'm glad to hear that. You've worked with, gee, about the greatest in the business, and the list keeps coming. And I'm really glad to see some of the younger players coming, Harry Allen and those guys, embracing this kind of music and keeping it alive.

MM: Harry told me that Johnny Mandel heard his record, called him on the phone, he didn't know him, called him on the phone and left a message on his answering machine saying he'd heard his CD and said how he was much relieved to know that jazz was in the hands of young players like him and how good it made him feel, which was a great day for Harry. But it's true. I mean you think that — I remember when Scott Hamilton came around for the first time. And nobody remembers particularly what was going on, now, at the time. But Scott was a real pioneer in a way, because it wasn't that he hadn't heard John Coltrane or Ornette or all the people we were talking about before. He'd heard all that, but he liked playing songs, and he liked playing, and everybody was like wow.

MR: What a concept.

MM: What a concept, you know, and here's this young guy doing it. He was in his twenties when I met him and he was playing like that. And I really think a lot of it is connected to Ruby Braff. Because Ruby went around bebop in a way. He's not really bebop. He was a song player, but a modern song player. Even though Louis Armstrong and Hackett, those were his influences. But Ruby harmonically and everything is very advanced and very understanding. But his songs, and I think he was a hero to a lot of these younger guys that came along. And Ruby kind of, like through that whole period, stuck to his gun, played great songs and never went the other route at all. And I think that's kind of the thread that runs then into Scott, and Harry is the next generation. Harry loved Scott. And we just did a tour in England with the two of them playing together, it was great. They both sounded wonderful. It was a pretty nice experience. So it is true there are young players out there that come along that have kind of digested the whole thing. Ken Peplowski is another one. I mean he probably has a better record collection, and is more eclectic than I have ever been as far as what he listens to and everything else. But he knows how he wants to play and what he loves is those songs, and carrying on that tradition.

MR: So you think the future of jazz — it still has a future?

MM: My feeling is everybody says at these jazz parties everybody's white haired in the audience and everything, and do you think there's a future, and I say well I think if we're lucky we'll all die off at the same time. And it will all go with the audience. But then Harry says well thanks a lot. And I actually sometimes, I don't know, I mean people say

that I like and trying to make a living at it. I'm a pessimist enough to think that if Frank Sinatra were starting out singing now, he'd have a hell of a time getting a job, because of the climate of the times and the kind of music that's popular. So I don't know. All I know is I'm 52 and maybe I could eke out a living for another 25 years. But I mean certainly it's going on in the schools, which I think there's a pro and con to that. I think that like classical music, when it got institutionalized, I don't think it was healthy for the music. But it got to the point where classical players only read notes off a page. But Mozart and Beethoven and up through Chopin, were all improvisers, they all would scare you to death. They'd throw each other themes and improvise on it. And I think now in jazz education a lot of that is happening in schools, where they have *The Real Book*, they have a set of chords and scales. And it's very much more of an institutionalized thing. And that's why I think it's important that guys like Harry, who are song players, that kind of thing is not being taught in the colleges. And so I think that's the important thread that's going through, is the Harry Allens and the Ken Peplowskis, and a lot of them coming out of music school, they don't know any songs. They can play their instruments and any chord, they can play a scale that goes with any chord, and play their originals or somebody else's originals, that are set up for these improvisations. But there's not the connection to the melody, and the love of the melody, and the great songs. In fact I have a student who is a young guitarist who is from this whole system that I was telling you about in college. He graduated. He plays great. I mean he plays the guitar beautifully. He plays beautiful solos and everything. And he's coming to me for lessons, to teach him songs, because he doesn't know any songs. And I say, "Well play a four bar intro" to something. He doesn't know how to play a four bar introduction. Well what do I do? It seems like that's the kind of thing that happens in schools. But when you come up playing on the street or playing in clubs, that's the kind of thing you want to learn when you're very young. In fact I was talking to Howard about it. I had an idea that that would be a good kind of school to start. It would be the American popular song and this kind of thing, and teach that.

MR: It sounds like a great idea and to have people teaching that are professional players. Because I think sometimes the students are being taught by teachers who have just been teachers. And that they are great players themselves, but as you say, they might not know the songs enough themselves that they can pass it on. I guess there's less venues to play and sometimes I think we don't need more players, we need more audience.

MM: Oh, I agree. And I feel that way about students a lot of times. And we've talked about it. Well you know this guy's not going to be a great player — why waste time with a student that's not very — I say well, you're making somebody that's going to go out, if nothing

all amateur athletes, and that's why sports demands so much money. But we're not amateur artists and we're not amateurs in this country. We're not amateur artists, we're not amateur musicians. And that's why the arts is in such bad shape. If everybody can appreciate what Michael Jordan does, because everybody's tried to shoot a basket at some time or another. But nobody's tried, it's not taught in schools anymore — music is not taught in elementary school like it was. And so people don't appreciate what Harry Allen can do. I mean if he were a comparable baseball player, he would be a national hero, just because everybody's played a little baseball in their life. And so I think it really goes back — when I say it's not good that it's in the schools, I think it should be much more exposure to jazz, good jazz, at a younger age, and maybe they wouldn't then turn around and buy the crap that they're buying at the age of twelve, fourteen years old. Had they heard something growing up at home, if they don't hear it at home, then they don't hear it in school, and they don't hear it on the radio, and they listen to what their peers say, and it's just a downward spiral. That's why it's so hard to find anything good.

MR: Lot of food for thought there. Speaking of food—

MM: Is it about that time?

MR: Where are you off to next?

MM: Let's see, Ames, Iowa this week, with Warren Vache and Gene. We're doing a concert there. We did one last year. It takes us a long time to get there, but it's fun once we're there.

MR: Well it's been a great pleasure for me.

MM: Well, Monk, it's been a real pleasure talking to you too.

MR: So on behalf of the college, I'd like to thank you for your time, and I hope that you have a good gig tonight and that no one throws tunes your way that you don't know.

MM: Well I mean at this point, it's been happening to me since I was 15. I ought to be used to it by now.

MR: All right. Good afternoon to you.

MM: Thank you.